

Sally Kuehnlein

UX Research Leader — Behavioural Science, Segmentation & Research Operations

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UX Research leader with over 20 years' experience spanning consumer brand (Microsoft/Skype), fitness tech (Freeletics, EGYM) and international B2B/B2C platforms. Specialises in motivation-psychology-based segmentation and JTBD frameworks, and in building the research operations — including AI-enabled repositories — that let insight outlive and outscale a single researcher. Known for translating theory and complex findings into language product, design and leadership can act on. Fluent in English and German.

CORE EXPERTISE

Segmentation & JTBD frameworks · Motivation psychology & behaviour change · AI-enabled research operations · Mixed-methods UX research · Stakeholder management & design workshops · Team leadership & mentoring · Fluent English & German

EXPERIENCE

Senior UX Researcher — EGYM

Jul 2024 – Present

Munich, Germany (Hybrid)

Interim UX Research Team Lead, Sep 2025 – Feb 2026

- Grew the UX Research team from two to five, including hiring a Head of UXR — then stepped back into an individual-contributor role to focus on applying motivation psychology and AI to research practice.
- Built a segmentation and JTBD framework grounded in self-determination theory — now embedded in product, marketing and partner (Wellpass) strategy — and am extending it into an AI-assisted framework connecting segment, motivation and measurable outcome.
- Designed and rolled out an AI-powered research repository (NotebookLM, ~200 studies) that cut insight retrieval from days — or not feasible at all — to self-serve minutes.
- Ran mixed-methods studies spanning exploratory research (physios and trainers, scoping a new product's market attractiveness), rapid iterative testing ahead of a trade-fair launch deadline, and IA testing to merge two B2B products' information architectures into one coherent experience.

Career Break

Sep 2023 – Jul 2024

Role made redundant in a company restructuring.

Design Research Manager — Freeletics GmbH

Jan 2019 – Sep 2023

Munich, Germany

- Led a team of five market and design researchers — hiring, development plans and the research budget.
- Replaced a fitness-level-only segmentation with one grounded in motivation psychology (SDT), personality and training behaviour — still the foundation of Freeletics' segmentation today, years after leaving.
- Ran "research bites" translating motivation theory into concrete product opportunities, embedding the framework into Marketing, design critiques and cross-functional workshops.
- Ran a wide range of mixed-methods studies across the product lifecycle, and coached non-researchers across the business to run their own research — extending research capacity beyond the team.

Design Researcher II — Microsoft (Skype)

Jun 2011 – Jan 2018

London, UK

- Led design research for mobile, desktop and web with a long-term focus on iOS, owning research through entire product lifecycles for high-priority releases.
- Ran iterative usability testing and desirability/emotion research that protected user trust through Skype's transition under Microsoft's ownership.
- Directed persona creation and cross-office (UK/US) workshops; triangulated primary research with BI, Marketing, Customer Support and secondary data for stronger, more tangible insight.

User Experience Consultant — GfK SirValUse

Sep 2010 – Jun 2011

London, UK

- Led usability and true-intent shopping research for eBay's Buyer experience, coordinating UK and US teams and a group of freelance moderators.

User Research Manager — XING AG

Feb 2005 – Aug 2010

Hamburg, Germany

- Embedded user research into XING's agile product development process; managed a research team of two.

Mentoring & Volunteering

Design Research Mentor, Climate-KIC EU Innovation Hub (2017–2019) · Mentor, UXPA London (2012–2015) — voluntary research mentoring for clean-tech startups and early-career UX professionals.

EDUCATION**MA Marketing Management, University of Westminster, UK**

2003 – 2004

BA (Hons) European Marketing with German, Leeds Metropolitan University, UK

1995 – 1998

CERTIFICATIONS & TRAINING

Certified Usability Analyst, Human Factors International (2009) · Certified in Information Organisation & Access, AIIM Europe (2010) · Advanced Qualitative Practice, Market Research Society UK (2014) · AI, UX & behavioural-science training (2023–2024)

INTERESTS

Hiking, cycling & the Bavarian mountains · garden & cooking · family · yoga